

FREE COMPANION RESOURCE

House Hacking Starter Kit

BY JOSH MOORE

Four tools. One clearer buy box.

Lender questions / 90-day plan

Property scorecard / Deal analyzer

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Educational use only. Verify property, financing, legal, tax, and insurance details with licensed professionals.

The lender may not count rent the way you do

You might see \$1,800 of market rent. An underwriter might use a reduced amount, require an appraisal rent schedule, review existing leases, or limit how income applies because you have little property-management history.

Fannie Mae guidance, for example, generally applies a 75% factor when qualifying rent is based on a lease or appraisal market rent. The balance accounts for vacancy and ongoing maintenance. Its treatment also varies by property type, current housing expense, documentation, and management history. ^[3]

Freddie Mac guidance permits eligible rental income from units the borrower will not occupy in a two- to four-unit primary residence, with documentation and calculation rules. ^[4]

Ask each lender:

- Can this property type use owner-occupied financing?
- How much proposed rent can you use to qualify me?
- What appraisal form or lease evidence will you need?
- Does my lack of landlord history change the calculation?
- What reserves, mortgage insurance, and occupancy period apply?
- Are there special rules for three- or four-unit properties or an ADU?

Get the answer for your file, not a general scenario.

Your 90-day plan

DAYS 1 TO 15

Readiness

Credit, cash, monthly budget, privacy, and repair tolerance.

DAYS 16 TO 30

Build the team

Three lenders, agent, inspector, insurance, legal, and tax help.

DAYS 31 TO 60

Learn the market

Track rents and sales. Tour. Call zoning. Analyze ten deals.

DAYS 61 TO 90

Set the buy box and act

Write limits. Screen listings. Offer only when the conservative case works.

The first goal is not an offer. It is a buy box you trust.

Property scorecard

Address _____

Date viewed _____ Asking price _____

Strategy _____

Score each item from 1 (poor) to 5 (strong).

Legal use and permits	1 2 3 4 5
Rent support	1 2 3 4 5
Privacy and layout	1 2 3 4 5
Parking and access	1 2 3 4 5
Building condition	1 2 3 4 5
Utilities and systems	1 2 3 4 5
Neighborhood rental demand	1 2 3 4 5
Insurance and hazard profile	1 2 3 4 5
Cash remaining after closing	1 2 3 4 5
Stress-tested affordability	1 2 3 4 5

TOTAL

_____ / 50

One-page deal analyzer

Purchase price	
Down payment and closing cash	
Immediate repairs and setup	
Cash remaining after closing	
Monthly principal and interest	
Taxes / insurance / MI / HOA	
Owner-paid utilities	
Maintenance reserve	
Capital replacement reserve	
Vacancy and collection allowance	
Other monthly costs	

TOTAL PLANNED OUTFLOW

MINUS CONSERVATIVE RENT

PLANNED HOUSING COST

STRESSED HOUSING COST

Largest likely first-year repair	
Decision	pursue / investigate / pass

Sources and next stops

Primary sources checked July 15, 2026. Recheck the rules when you are ready to buy.

1

HUD: FHA loan basics

www.hud.gov/helping-americans/loans

2

U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs: VA Home Loans

www.benefits.va.gov/HOMELOANS/

3

Fannie Mae Selling Guide B3-3.8-01: Rental Income

selling-guide.fanniemae.com/sel/b3-3.8-01/rental-income

4

Freddie Mac Guide 5306.1: Rental Income

guide.freddiemac.com/app/guide/section/5306.1

5

CFPB: Buying a House and mortgage disclosures

www.consumerfinance.gov/owning-a-home/

6

HUD Housing Counselor Training: Fair Housing Overview

hudhousingcounselors.hud.gov/sites/default/files/study_pdfs/Module%203.1_20...

7

EPA: Lead-Based Paint Disclosure Rule

www.epa.gov/lead/lead-based-paint-disclosure-rule-section-1018-title-x

8

IRS Publication 527: Residential Rental Property

www.irs.gov/publications/p527

9

IRS Publication 523: Selling Your Home

www.irs.gov/publications/p523

10

HUD: Find a housing counselor

www.hud.gov/stat/sfh/housing-counseling

Local answers still matter.

Check zoning, permits, landlord-tenant law, insurance, taxes, and lender rules for your file.